

- RAG Learning

3.3 Language of Journalism (Paper 3 pathway)

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 3 Investigating Language

The Journalism pathway investigates how news constructs meaning through language. Key frameworks: **news values** (Galtung & Ruge), **Critical Discourse Analysis** (Fairclough), **inverted pyramid** structure, **tabloid vs broadsheet** register, and multimodal analysis for print and digital news.

3.3.1 News Values — Galtung & Ruge (1965)

Criteria by which stories are selected as news:

- **Frequency / recency** — events fitting news schedules.
- **Threshold** — magnitude of an event.
- **Unambiguity** — clear interpretation.
- **Meaningfulness** — cultural and geographical closeness.
- **Consonance** — matches existing expectations.
- **Unexpectedness** — genuinely surprising events.
- **Continuity** — ongoing stories easier to follow.
- **Composition** — balance within an issue.
- **Elitism** — powerful people, nations.
- **Personalisation** — human-interest angle.
- **Negativity** — bad news preferred.

3.3.2 Tabloid vs Broadsheet Register

	Tabloid	Broadsheet
Headlines	Puns, alliteration, short monosyllabic Anglo-Saxon lexis, caps	Longer, more neutral, Latinate lexis
Syntax	Short declaratives, minor sentences, noun-phrase fragments	Balanced complex-compound sentences
Register	Informal, emotive, direct address	Formal, detached, institutional voice
Quotation	Sparse, often single source	Extensive with attribution
Graphology	Large images, bold colours, red banners	Smaller images, restrained colour

3.3.3 Story Structure — The Inverted Pyramid

Standard news reports place the most important information first, with progressively less important detail. This allows readers to stop at any point without missing the main story. Typical components:

- **Headline** — bold title designed to attract.
- **Strapline / sub-head** — secondary line with detail.
- **Byline** — journalist's name.
- **Dateline** — place and date.
- **Lead / lede** — opening paragraph answering who/what/when/where.
- **Body** — detail and quotation in decreasing importance.
- **Kicker** — striking closing phrase or image.

3.3.4 Fairclough — CDA and Synthetic Personalisation

Norman Fairclough's **Critical Discourse Analysis** treats every text as social practice encoding ideology. Applied to journalism:

- **Lexical choice** — "migrants" vs "invaders" encodes stance.
- **Grammar** — active/passive redistributes agency; nominalisation hides processes.
- **Graphology** — image selection, cropping, captioning frame meaning.
- **Synthetic personalisation** — intimate/inclusive language simulating a personal relationship with mass audience (e.g. "WE all want safer streets").

3.3.5 Tabloidese — Distinctive Lexical Style

- Short action verbs: *slam* (criticise), *axe* (sack), *spark* (cause), *rap* (rebuke), *blast* (attack).
- Compressed adjective-noun strings: *sick fiend killer dad*.
- Emotive modifiers: *outrage*, *chaos*, *fury*.
- Euphemism for taboo: *romp*, *love nest*.
- Puns and alliteration: *Freddie starr ate my hamster*.

3.3.6 Representation and Framing

Every choice frames the event. Compare:

- "Police shot the protester" (active — police foregrounded).
- "The protester was shot by police" (passive — protester foregrounded).
- "Shots were fired" (agent removed entirely).

Studies of protest coverage (Hall, Nash, van Dijk) show tabloid framing often constructs protestors as threat and police as protectors through lexical, grammatical and visual choices.

3.3.7 Multimodal Analysis

- **Image selection** — which photograph represents which person.
- **Cropping and composition** — what is foregrounded.
- **Caption lexis** — anchors the image's meaning.
- **Anchorage vs relay** (Barthes) — text either fixing image meaning or adding new information.

- **Typography** — font choice signalling register (serif = authoritative; bold sans-serif = urgent).
- **Colour** — red banners signal alarm; black on white signals seriousness.

3.3.8 Online News — Distinctive Features

- **Hyperlinks** — allow non-linear reading.
- **Video embeds** — multimodal immediacy.
- **Continuous updating** — stories evolve.
- **Comment threads** — reader interaction.
- **Clickbait conventions** — curiosity gap, question format, emotive hook.
- **SEO-friendly headlines** — keyword-led, less punning.

3.3.9 Genres of Journalism

Genre	Features
Hard news	Breaking political/economic events; neutral register; inverted pyramid
Soft news	Lifestyle, celebrity; personal register; narrative openings
Opinion column	First-person voice, anecdote, rhetorical questions
Editorial	Unsigned institutional voice; formal Latinate; persuasive
Feature article	In-depth treatment; narrative + analysis
Investigative journalism	Longform; research-led; reveals hidden facts
Literary journalism	Narrative non-fiction; crafted prose

Applied Example: A tabloid front page: "MIGRANT TIDE: Britain under siege". Lexis (migrant, tide, siege) draws on semantic fields of natural disaster + warfare. Grammar (minor-sentence fragment, prepositional phrase "under siege") dramatises. Graphology (all caps, red banner)

signals alarm. Pragmatically, the headline presupposes migration = invasion, positioning readers as threatened. Alternative lexis (asylum seekers, arrivals) would produce a different representation. Paper 3 analysis evaluates the ideological work done by such choices.

3.3.10 How to Analyse a Journalism Text

1. Identify the **genre** (hard / soft / opinion / editorial / feature).
2. Identify the **publication type** (tabloid / broadsheet / online).
3. Apply **Galtung & Ruge**'s news values to the story selection.
4. Analyse **linguistic features** — lexis, grammar, graphology.
5. Apply **Fairclough**'s CDA — ideology encoded in everyday choices.
6. Consider **multimodal** elements — image, caption, colour.
7. Evaluate **representation** — what version of the event is constructed?

Paper 3 Tip: Edexcel Paper 3 rewards named theorists. Cite Galtung & Ruge, Fairclough, Hall, van Dijk by name and link them to specific text features. Integrate multimodal analysis with lexical/grammatical analysis. Top-band answers evaluate ideology, not just list features.

Key Terms Checklist

News values (Galtung & Ruge), inverted pyramid, headline / strapline / byline / lead / kicker, tabloid / broadsheet, tabloidese, synthetic personalisation, CDA (Fairclough), framing, representation, active / passive, nominalisation, presupposition, anchorage / relay (Barthes), hard / soft news, editorial, op-ed, clickbait, multimodal analysis.